

A Question for the Left: What Level of Productive Forces Do You Think Is Needed to Achieve Communism? Do the Left Have a Methodology for Getting Society to Such a Level of Productive Forces?

Zhihu

On the question of building socialism in backward countries, both the theory and the practice of the Marxist tradition have left behind much discussion.

Marx's earliest statement on the productive-force conditions for achieving communism comes from *The German Ideology*:

This "estrangement" (to use a term which will be comprehensible to the philosophers) can of course only be abolished given two practical premises. To become an "intolerable" power, i.e. a power against which men make a revolution, it must necessarily have rendered the great mass of humanity "propertyless," and moreover in contradiction to an existing world of wealth and culture, both of which premises presuppose a great increase in productive power, a high degree of its development. And, on the other hand, this development of productive forces (which itself implies the actual empirical existence of men in their world-historical, instead of local, being) is absolutely necessary as a practical premise: firstly, because without it only want is made general, and with destitution the struggle for necessities and all the old filthy business would necessarily be reproduced; secondly, because only with this universal development of productive forces is universal intercourse between men established, which produces in all nations simultaneously the phenomenon of the "propertyless" mass (universal competition), making each nation dependent on the revolutions of the others, and finally puts world-historical, empirically universal individuals in place of local ones.

To put Marx's words in plain language:

First, without the development of the productive forces, small-producer society will not dissolve, and the great majority of labourers will not become proletarians. We know that among all the classes of modern society, only the proletariat tends toward communism; the other classes are either feudal-conservative or tend toward capitalism.

Second, if communism is attempted under backward productive forces, it can only be "everyone poor together" — something like the "ascetic, all-life-enjoyment-renouncing, Spartan communism" Engels speaks of in *Socialism: Utopian and Scientific*. But Marx and Engels held that this communism of

people scrambling for the necessities of life has no way out, and must end in "all the old filthy business" reviving.

Third, only the development of the productive forces can form a unified world market that draws in all nations, with division of labour and cooperation within that single world market, proletarianising most of the labourers of every nation — turning them into wage-workers — so that the transformations of each nation influence and depend on one another. Although Marx made this point in the 1840s, we are still within this historical process; it will take about another 30–40 years to complete.

Of the three points above, the backward countries fail the first and second; and the historical fact that post-revolutionary nations could only build socialism alone shows that the third was not satisfied either.

But in his later years, Marx, writing specifically of a nation like Russia with many survivals of pre-capitalist relations of production, proposed a possibility of leapfrog development — "crossing the Caudine Forks of the capitalist regime."

My special study of this question on the basis of the original sources convinced me: this rural commune is the fulcrum of the social regeneration of Russia; but for it to function as such, one must first remove the destructive influences which assail it from all sides, and then ensure it the normal conditions of natural development. — Marx's letter to Vera Zasulich

Marx very cautiously said that the common ownership of the Russian rural commune, if encouraged by the new regime after the revolution and given advanced production techniques, could possibly grow and flourish in the new society. Of course, we know that many post-revolutionary countries used the squeezing of the peasantry as the principal means of primitive accumulation for industrialisation. In such circumstances, the rural commune never obtained "the normal conditions of natural development" — it would be strange if it had developed well.

According to the basic Marxist view, a revolution in a backward country like Russia, without the support of advanced countries such as Germany, could not build socialism. Then, in the situation where the German revolution failed while the Russian revolution succeeded, should Russia build socialism, or be content with developing capitalism while doing its best to raise the conditions of the workers?

Lenin, in refuting the Mensheviks, said:

"Russia's productive forces have not yet reached the level that makes socialism possible." This thesis of the heroes of the Second International, including of course Sukhanov, is their stock-in-trade. They repeat it in a thousand different keys, regarding it as the decisive argument in their appraisal of our revolution. But if the building of socialism requires a certain level of culture (although no one can say

what this particular "level of culture" is, since it differs in every West European country), why cannot we begin by first achieving the prerequisites for that level through revolutionary means, and then, on the basis of workers' and peasants' government and the Soviet system, catch up with the other nations? Our Sukhanovs — not to speak of the social-democrats further to the right than they — never even dream that revolutions cannot be made otherwise. Our European philistines never dream that in the Eastern countries, with their enormous populations and incomparably more complex social conditions, the coming revolution will undoubtedly display more peculiarities than the Russian revolution. — Lenin, "On Our Revolution (A propos of N. Sukhanov's Notes)"

On the basis of Lenin's view, Stalin developed it into the "empty-land thesis": since "there are no ready-made germs of a socialist economy in the country, the Soviet government must create new socialist forms of economy, so to speak, on 'empty land.'" But in fact, Lenin's economic policy in his final years moved from war communism to the New Economic Policy — state capitalism. Lenin told the whole party very plainly that the essence of the NEP was the restoration of capitalist relations of production:

The new economic policy means replacing the surplus-appropriation system with a tax in kind — it means a return to capitalism in a considerable degree. To what degree, we do not know. Concession contracts with foreign capitalists (though, admittedly, very few have been signed so far, particularly compared with our proposals), and the leasing of enterprises to private capitalists — these are direct restorations of capitalism, which grow directly from the roots of the new economic policy. For the abolition of the surplus-appropriation system means that the peasants may freely sell their surplus produce after paying the tax, and the tax in kind levies only a small part of their output. Since the peasants constitute a huge proportion of the population and of the whole economy, capitalism cannot but grow on this soil of free trade. — Lenin, "The New Economic Policy and the Tasks of the Political Education Departments"

Of course, Lenin's aim in carrying out the NEP was not really to build Russia into a West-European-style capitalist country, but simply to admit that the conditions for building communism did not yet exist, nor the conditions for a direct transition to socialism — capitalism had to be used to restore the economy and improve the people's living standards. Lenin held that, on the basis of the capitalist commodity economy, with the state holding the principal means of production, the key was to organise the peasants into the collective economy through cooperatives and gradually raise their cultural level. The cooperative was the most appropriate means of transition to socialism for a backward country whose population was mainly peasants.

In point of fact, the only thing we have to do is to make our population "civilised" enough to understand all the advantages of everybody participating in the cooperatives, and to get them to participate. "Only" that, nothing more. At present we need no other clever ways of making the transition to socialism. But in order to accomplish this "only" thing, a whole revolution is needed, a

whole epoch of cultural advance of the entire mass of the people.... But in order to get every member of the population to participate in the cooperatives through the new economic policy, a whole historical epoch is required. In the best possible case, we shall have to pass through this epoch in one or two decades. Nevertheless, it is a special historical epoch, and without passing through this epoch, without making everyone literate, without giving them sufficient understanding, without fully teaching the population to read books and newspapers, and without the material basis for this — without certain safeguards, such as protection against bad harvests, famine, and so on — we shall not achieve our aim.... Once this cultural revolution is accomplished, our country will become a completely socialist country. But this cultural revolution presents extraordinary difficulties for us, both in the purely cultural sphere (for we are illiterate) and in the material sphere (for to be cultured we must have a fairly developed production of material means of production, and a fairly solid material base). — Lenin, "On Cooperation"

According to Lenin, building socialism requires a cultural foundation; socialism cannot be built by a heap of illiterates. Yet in 1939, three years after Stalin declared socialism built, about 20% of the Soviet population was still illiterate^[1].

Before industrialisation is completed, before the peasants have been organised into cooperatives and become cultured people, communism is impossible. At such a stage, one can at most claim to be building socialism, not to have built it. Any blind attempt that does not respect the basic laws of historical materialism can only end in tragedy. No matter how revolutionary or how idealistic the rulers are, it will not help — sometimes it even makes things worse. After the failure of left-adventurist overreach, the masses will turn to the right, bid farewell to revolution altogether, and take the capitalist road.

Notes

^[1] "Soviet Education and Social Mobility 1921–1934": the Soviet census of early 1939, the first published since 1926, found that 81% of the population aged 9 and above was literate (measured by ability to read or write).

中文原文：《苏联教育与社会流动 1921-1934》1939年初，自1926年以来首次公布的苏联人口普查发现，在9岁及以上人口中，81%具有读写能力（以能够阅读或写作为标准）

<https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/2014991357274509464>

This article was originally published on Zhihu (in Chinese): <https://www.zhihu.com/question/1951633852826092981/answer/2062296139970393600> Author: 最最遥远的路 · Zhihu profile: <https://www.zhihu.com/people/zui-zui-yao-yuan-de-lu-32/posts>

本文原发表于知乎专栏/回答（中文）：<https://www.zhihu.com/question/1951633852826092981/answer/206229613997039360>
o: 作者：最最遥远的路：<https://www.zhihu.com/people/zui-zui-yao-yuan-de-lu-32/posts>